

# Desirable Futures *with robots*



A series of distributed workshops, inventing a caring, feminist, *humanist* narrative for social robots — reclaiming a question that has, so far, been answered mostly outside HRI.

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## I From laboratory to industry.

Robotics is shifting fast. In the past three years, parts of the field — humanoid platforms most visibly, but also home, delivery, service, and care robots — have moved from laboratory subfields to industry-led races: multi-trillion-dollar market forecasts, sizeable state investment in China, South Korea, and elsewhere, and capable, increasingly affordable platforms reaching the market (Unitree's G1 humanoid at around \$16K USD is one indicator).

Within one to two years, autonomous and semi-autonomous robots — humanoid or otherwise — are expected to be present in everyday life: at home, at work, in care, in public space. HRI has a narrow window in which to shape the discourse. Practically, the next eighteen to twenty-four months.

## II Efficiency. Productivity. Replacement.

The prevailing framing rests on a stable set of arguments: robots will perform jobs that are dull, dirty, or dangerous; offset labour shortages; save human time; and — most visibly through the humanoid wave — represent the next stage of the AI race, a step from text and image into *physical AI*.

*Across these arguments runs a consistent through-line: robots are positioned in **competition with humans** — on labour, on time, on capability.*

The early effects of letting this framing harden are visible in generative AI. With embodied robots — humanoid or otherwise — the same logic extends into domestic, relational, civic, and intimate domains, settings where the criteria of *efficiency* and *replacement* translate poorly.

## III Reclaiming the narrative.

Without explicit debate, much of robotics has begun to converge on a narrow vision — robots as efficient surrogates for human labour, with the humanoid form as the most visible default. The convergence is largely silent: never formally decided, never ethically justified, sustained by media coverage, capital, and funding incentives.

It deserves to be examined. *Human-centred* design is not the same as *human-shaped* design — and the question is not only how to design a robot, but whether and when a robot is the right answer at all. The HRI community has a responsibility to keep these distinctions live, and, where possible, to **reclaim the narrative**.

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Can we invent a caring, feminist, *humanist* narrative for social robots?

Each workshop opens with a *what if* that reverses one element of the dominant framing — and asks participants to imagine a desirable future growing from there.

*Not dystopia. Not subversion for its own sake.* A future they would actually want.

Below: the starting bank. Pick one, adapt one, or invent your own. Send new prompts back so the bank grows.

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01 What if robots *didn't always say yes* to our orders?

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02 What if a robot was *clumsy*, and needed our help — all the time?

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03 What if a robot didn't try to *save* your time, but to *waste it well*?

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04 What if a robot brought you *something you never asked for*?

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ADD YOUR OWN

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05 

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06 

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07 

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The rationale needs translation, not simplification. Below: short notes for four common audiences. Adapt to your context, your language, your room. These are starting points, not scripts.

## Children

### INTRODUCE AS

A storybook framing. *"Imagine a robot who..."* Centre the robot as a character with feelings, quirks, and refusals — not a tool.

### INVERSIONS THAT RESONATE

Clumsiness. Surprise gifts. A robot that doesn't always say yes. Friendship over function.

### WATCH-OUTS

Avoid abstract policy framings. Avoid scary-robot tropes. Keep concrete and playful.

## Adolescents

### INTRODUCE AS

A speculative-design brief. *"Design the robot you would actually want — for yourself, in five years."*

### INVERSIONS THAT RESONATE

Refusal. Identity. Time-wasting (in good ways). Robots that protect rather than monitor.

### WATCH-OUTS

Don't moralise. Don't anchor only to school-or-work framings. Make space for ambivalence.

## Older adults

### INTRODUCE AS

A conversation about everyday life and care, not technology. Start from *what works well now* and ask where a robot might fit — if at all.

### INVERSIONS THAT RESONATE

Needing-help (from the robot, not toward it). Presence over function. Robots that *aren't* caregivers.

### WATCH-OUTS

Avoid framings that read as condescending. The "lonely older person + companion robot" assumption deserves to be opened, not reinforced.

## Workers (warehouse, care, service)

### INTRODUCE AS

A frank discussion about the workplace they know — what's dignified about it, what's not, where robots are already arriving, and what a desirable shift would look like.

### INVERSIONS THAT RESONATE

Co-presence rather than replacement. Robots that hand off rather than take over. Time given back, on the worker's terms.

### WATCH-OUTS

Acknowledge precarity directly. Avoid techno-optimism. Be specific about who benefits and who pays in each scenario.

Each workshop should produce at least one *desirable future*, captured on the report form (page 5). Four formats below — pick the one that fits your audience, time, and space. Role-play is recommended: it places people *in* situation rather than reasoning *about* it.

**RECOMMENDED**

## Role-play / theatre

~60 min · groups of 3–6 · low-prop, low-cost

**STRUCTURE**

Introduce one *what if*. Assign roles (a person, the robot, an observer). Play out a five-minute scene. Debrief. Re-play with one element changed.

**WHAT TO CAPTURE**

Title of the scene; who/what/where; the moment of the desirable future; what changed between runs.

## Drawing

~45 min · individuals, then share · paper + pens

**STRUCTURE**

Introduce the *what if*. Fifteen minutes of individual sketching (the robot, the moment, the place). Round-robin share. Cluster ideas.

**WHAT TO CAPTURE**

One to three representative sketches with brief captions. The cluster of ideas the group recognised in common.

## Speculative fictions

~60–90 min · individuals or pairs · in *writing* (a short essay or vignette) or in *art* (a painting or drawing)

**STRUCTURE**

Introduce one *what if*. Brief world-building together (who, where, when). Each participant then writes a short speculative vignette *or* makes one finished image of a scene from that future. Share — read aloud, or exhibit and discuss.

**WHAT TO CAPTURE**

The text or artwork itself (scan or photograph it); a title; one or two sentences naming the desirable future it embodies.

## Brainstorming

~30 min · small group · post-its or notebook

**STRUCTURE**

Three minutes of silent ideation. Round-robin share. Cluster on the wall or page. Vote on the two ideas the group wants to live in.

**WHAT TO CAPTURE**

The top two or three desirable futures with the rationale the group gave for each.

## Interviews

~30 min per pair · one-on-one or pairs

**STRUCTURE**

Introduce the *what if*. Open-ended questions about the person's life, then about how a robot might fit (if at all). Record answers carefully.

**WHAT TO CAPTURE**

One to three direct quotes; the recurring concerns or hopes across interviews; the desirable future each person sketched out in their own words.

| DATE  | LOCATION | RESEARCHER | TARGET GROUP | FORMAT                                                | PARTICIPANTS |
|-------|----------|------------|--------------|-------------------------------------------------------|--------------|
| _____ | _____    | _____      | _____        | role-play, drawing,<br>brainstorming,<br>interview... | _____        |

*What if...* \_\_\_\_\_

TITLE OF THIS DESIRABLE FUTURE

SHORT DESCRIPTION

IMAGE

*Sketch directly, photograph, or attach separately and reference here.*

*A drawing, a diagram, a photo of the  
workshop output — anything that  
helps the future feel concrete.*

**01** What *future* does this imagine? (Not the robot — the life around it.)

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\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

**03** What does this robot *refuse* — or simply not do?

\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

**02** The robot's *role, shape, and place* in that future.

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\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

**04** Why is this future *desirable*?

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\_\_\_\_\_